



GNU License (GPL)

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History



- In 1983, Richard Stallman started the GNU Project.
- The goal was to create software that users could freely use, study, modify, and share.
- In 1985, he founded the Free Software Foundation to support the free software movement.
- The GNU GPL was created to legally protect software freedom through the concept of copyleft.

Description



What is GNU GPL?

- GNU General Public License (GPL) is a free and open-source software license.
- It allows users to:
 - Run the software for any purpose.
 - Access and study the source code.
 - Modify the software.
 - Share the software with others.
- GPL is designed to protect software freedom and encourage collaboration among developers.

GNU GPL Versions

GNU GPL has evolved over time to better protect software freedom and keep up with technology changes. There are 3 major versions.

TIMELINE

01

GPL v1 (1989)

- First release by Richard Stalman
- Focused on protecting software freedom



02

GPL v2 (1991)

- Stronger copyleft protection
- Required source code availability
- Widely used (Linux Kernel)



03

GPL v3 (2007)

- Added patent protection
- Prevented "Tivoization" and DRM restrictions
- Improved compatibility with modern software



VERSION COMPARISON

Version	Year	Key Improvement
GPL v1	1989	• Initial release • Protected software freedom
GPL v2	1991	• Stronger copyleft protection • Required source code availability • Widely used (Linux Kernel)
GPL v3	2007	• Added patent protection • Prevented "Tivoization" and DRM restrictions • Improved compatibility with modern software



SUMMARY

All three GPL versions share the same goal:
to **ensure software remains free for everyone.**



Condition/Constraints

Source Code Access

- You must provide the complete source code when distributing the software.
- You cannot share only a ready-to-run file.
- Anyone receiving the software has the right to view, study, and change the raw code.



Condition/Constraints

Legal Rules and Tracking

- You must keep all original copyright notices exactly as they are.
- You must include a full copy of the GNU General Public License with the software.
- You must clearly mark any files you modified and include the date of the change.

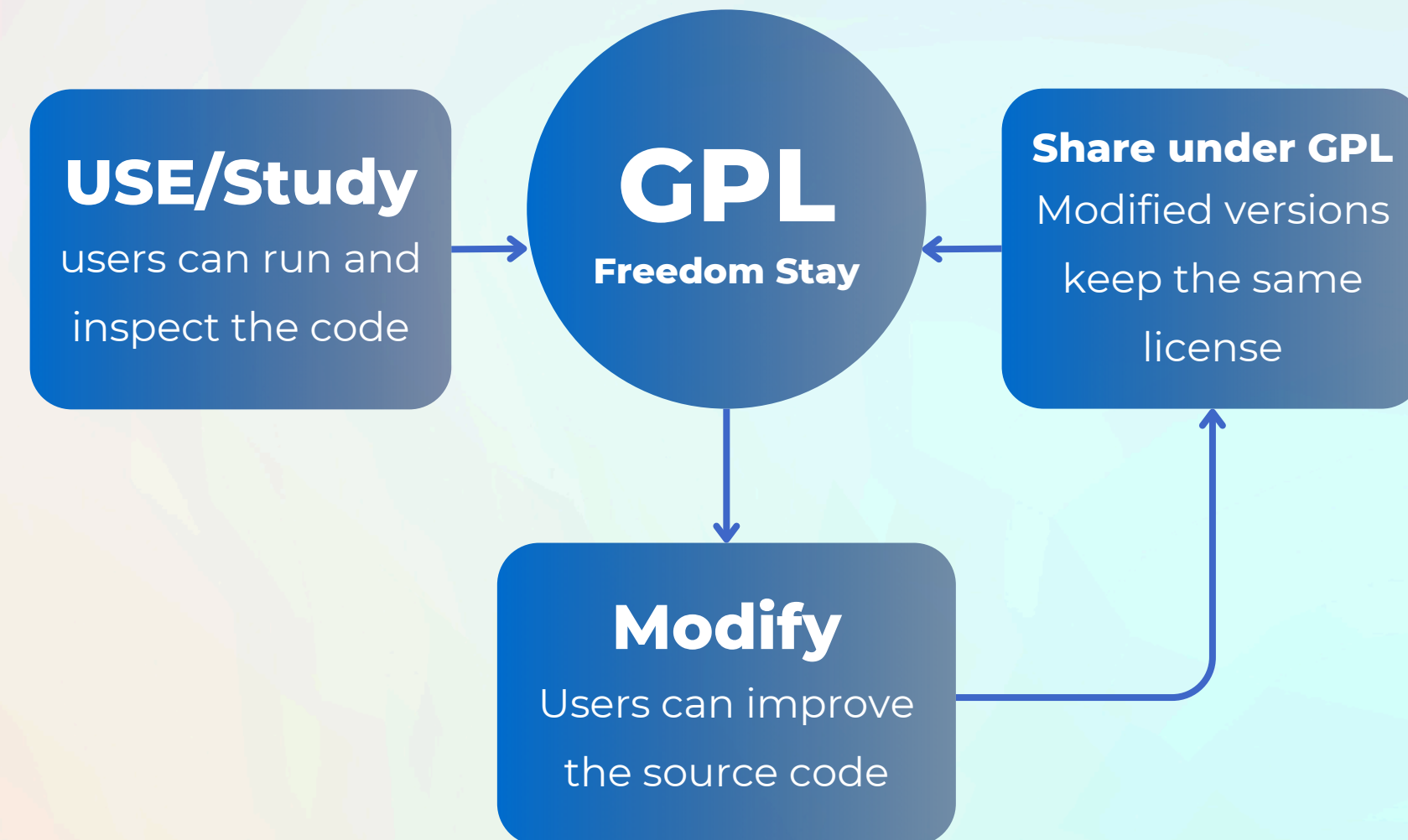
Copyleft

The main idea that makes GPL different from permissive licenses.

Core meaning

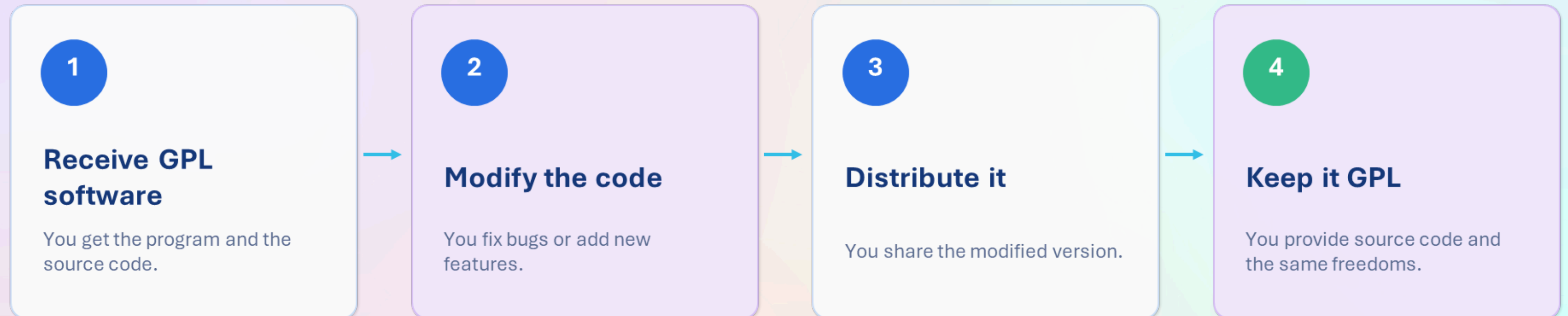
Copyleft uses copyright to protect software freedom.

- Users can use, copy, study, modify, and share the software.
- If a modified version is distributed, it must also stay under GPL.
- The next users receive the same freedoms as the original users.
- This prevents GPL software from becoming closed-source.



How Copyleft Works

The rule becomes important when the modified program is distributed.



Key message: You can change GPL software, but if you distribute it, you must pass the same freedom forward.



What Must Be Included?

When you distribute a modified GPL program, these conditions matter.

Must do

- Provide the complete source code.
- Keep the GPL license with the software.
- Keep original copyright notices.
- Mark modified files and dates.
- License the modified version under GPL.

Cannot Do

- Do not hide the source code.
- Do not change it into closed-source software.
- Do not add extra restrictions that remove GPL freedoms.

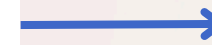
In short: same freedom, same GPL.

GPLv2 vs GPLv3 Copyleft

Both protect the same freedom, but GPLv3 updates the protection for modern software.

GPLv2

- Strong copyleft protection
- Requires source code access
- Same rights for recipients



GPLv3

- Keeps the same copyleft idea
- Adds patent protection
- Protects against DRM and hardware lock-down

GPLv2 already protects copyleft, while GPLv3 adds stronger modern protections such as patents, DRM, and hardware restrictions.

Examples Software that uses GPL V2 & V3

Many popular pieces of software are released under the GNU license. Here are a few well known examples:

GPLv2

1. Linux Kernel
2. Git
3. WordPress
4. MySQL community edition

GPLv3 OR “GPL v2 or later”

1. VLC Media player
2. Audacity
3. Inkscape
4. Many software products from the GNU project - GNU bash, GNU Emacs, GCC, ...

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Thank You.
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